

Tomorrow

The morning of Saba's 25th birthday began with alarming silence. Typically, he is awoken by the fighting of his parents. But despite the absence of noise, the silence was still unconventional. It was measured—the type of silence that fills the room before a jury reads the verdict or when a doctor returns with test results.

Saba rolled out of bed and looked out the window to a familiar, gloomy sight. Their world-state stretched endlessly, consumed by the grey morning sky. District 11's geometric pillars of black glass projected the usual advertisement from Cloud V:

“With Purpose, We Live.
With Purpose, Tomorrow is Earned.”

These words had a different meaning for Saba today, as tears began to drip from his eyes. He continued looking below the slogan—at the golden, rotating hologram heads appearing one at a time. Each with a smile:

101 years continued. 203 years continued. And then, of course, the world leader, King Tame: 316 years continued. And further down, at the base of the pillars, memorial walls wrapped around the city blocks, illuminated with new names from the previous night.

Saba became reluctant to keep looking. He went to the kitchen and found his mother pretending to wash dishes that were already clean. He opened the fridge and poured himself only a cup of milk.

“You should eat,” Saba's mother suggested.

Saba caught himself staring at his mother for a moment. He was unsettled by how little separated the two of them now. At twenty-five, his mother looked more like his sister than his parent. The only difference came from the eyes. With droopy eyelids and purplish circles beneath, she was simply a woman exhausted by more tomorrows than Saba.

“I'm okay momma—seriously,” responded Saba. His mother hesitantly nodded and continued shining the dishes. But the measured silence kicked in again. Saba's lies were easily heard. In an attempt to relax, Saba sat at the dining room table with his glass of milk. He hoped to soak in the little life that remained in the world—morning traffic, drones, and distant church bells. He also heard young children laughing freely on their way to school. It was calming to hear. There was something untouched about children. They still spoke about the future like it belonged to them.

Humanity conquered biological death just over 320 years ago. Now, every person received the Vigh-77 surgical implant in the back of their neck at birth. But its abilities remained dormant until one reached 25 years of age. Prior to this milestone, young people aged, got sick, and died from natural causes.

But then came *Appreciation Day*. The Vigh-77 activated and ceased the possibility of death by disease. The body stopped aging, and cells regenerated both rapidly and eternally. At first, the world celebrated this achievement. Government viewed it as an ascension. Ministry viewed it as salvation. But to the scientists at Cloud V, it was the greatest moment in history. Death had been eradicated.

And for a while, the sentiment felt true. There was no longer the pain of funerals or witnessing loved ones endure the torment of cancer. But humanity found itself unable to sustain room. Land maximized possible expansion. Oceans

completely vanished beneath artificial districts. It was only about 40 years before food shortages globalized and social unrest began due to scarcity of resources.

Then chaos erupted. As overcrowding took its course, district riots became a ritual. People within the districts grew hostile toward larger families, particularly those with many children. Some even stooped as low as killing children to prevent them from reaching immortality, and districts found themselves with questionably high child mortality rates. It was clear that desperation was spreading throughout the world-state. In turn, some districts implemented birth restrictions.

But this hostility could not be contained. So, King Tame introduced Cloud V's *Continuation system* in an attempt to cease overpopulation and improve society. Every night following *Appreciation Day*, the Vigh-77 implant evaluated its host. If one failed evaluation, the implant did not continue their conscious activity the next morning, acting as the new form of death. People assumed it was a painless experience, but the true horror stemmed from the uncertainty of tomorrow. There were no clear guidelines. It was a process that seemed subjective. Many questioned the judgement. Was it one's success? Was it one's intentions? Empathy? Impact on society? A question that continued to go unanswered. The continuation system evolved rapidly. Cloud V once believed they could predict outcomes via biological and behavioral data across the districts. But outcomes and data began to severely misalign over the centuries. Scientists could no longer interpret why certain people survived while others did not. Yet, Cloud V presented it as balance. The people, though, simply called it "tomorrow."

Over the years, that uncertainty reshaped society. People had become obsessed with appearing worthy for continuation. The norm was to wake up at 7:30 AM—any later was considered lost time. Every minute carried the pressure of one proving they deserved another day. In the workplace, employers tracked behavioral consistency and productivity by the hour. Newscasts had essentially become broadcasts to promote social contribution. It was unclear if any of these measures taken even mattered. Nobody truly knew. But everyone shared a common goal: *Tomorrow*.

"Do you remember what I told you?" Saba's mother asked with cracks in her voice.

Saba slowly nodded. "Tomorrow isn't promised," he recited. At twenty-five, people no longer feared dying someday—they feared being judged tonight.

"Those words hold much different meaning than when my mother used to tell me that. But you will be okay," his mother responded, though she struggled to look Saba in the eyes. She then grabbed the dish towel tightly in her hands. "I used to pray you would stay a kid forever," she admitted softly. "Of course, I loved seeing you grow up, but children still belonged to life back then."

As his mother spoke, Saba began to look out the window. His eyes opened to the reality of adulthood. Neighbors spoke to one another conservatively. And from a distance, interactions appeared strangely rehearsed, though he couldn't touch on why.

His mother's voice continued to weaken, "I spent 25 years trying not to think about this day for you. It came much quicker than I anticipated."

At midnight, *appreciation* began. Saba felt a soothing vibration in his head. He started to get a warm feeling inside. Aches that he didn't know he had were disappearing. His breathing had never felt so fluid. His thoughts were never so clear. The rush of immortality felt surreal to Saba. But it was overshadowed by fear. He was now being watched. In angst, he failed to get much sleep that night. But at 7:30 AM, he was awoken by the loud chatter of his parents. His eyes opened with burning relief. Saba had made it—his first tomorrow.

Looking outside his window this morning was a much different experience. Saba was no longer oblivious to the morning struggles of the world. This time, as the church bells rang across the city, he witnessed people stepping onto their balconies, embracing loved ones after a successful continuation. Some cried openly as their loved ones failed to make it. Others simply looked at the cloudy skies silently, grateful another morning had arrived.

Three months later, District 11 found itself in a state of disparity. It had seen a drastic fall in continuation rates. Each morning, new names overpopulated the memorial walls. Church bells were ringing extraordinarily longer than usual. “And More,” it stated at the bottom of the list. This was unheard of in the districts. Then Arthur Tame—son of King Tame—began to appear.

Citizens of district 11 grew worried. They had assumed these visits were temporary—maybe to help get the district back in order. But Arthur kept appearing, surrounded by large, armored vehicles, each with a shiny gold Cloud V emblem. With no announcement and no evident reason, he visited the continuation memorial and District 11’s food shelter on a day-to-day basis.

One day, Saba walked down the streets of his district and into his local food shelter. From there, he caught sight of Arthur Tame through the window. There he was, with his usual convoy and golden suit. It was clear he didn’t fit in with the people of District 11. To Saba, he looked nothing like how he is portrayed in Cloud V promotions. He didn’t have that strong and intimidating nature that his advertised character possessed. Instead, his body language suggested a surprising sense of exhaustion.

Saba continued to look at Arthur from inside the food shelter, which sat directly across District 11’s continuation memorial. He also noticed the surrounding pedestrians walk by as they pretended not to stare at Arthur. Volunteers within the food bank began to gossip. “Why is he here?” someone whispered.

“It’s probably a publicity stunt,” Saba answered, holding his arms tightly. He continued, “What better way to show you care than to visit the districts? It’s easy for him to show up, smile, and then leave. He is nothing more than a phony poster boy for what a ‘worthy citizen’ should look like.”

Arthur entered the food bank and immediately approached an elderly volunteer. He helped her lift a box of fruit to the back. She was one of the few remaining citizens who received the Vigh-77 too late to keep their youth.

“Performative,” Saba shouted from across the shelter. But he was unacknowledged. Saba once again noticed his peers attempting to ignore Arthur’s presence. All eyes remained down. The little conversation that did occur happened around Arthur, but never toward him. Seeking acknowledgement, Saba stepped forward, and he shouted again, “Arthur Vale!”

Arthur turned his head. “You know who I am,” he said.

Saba’s eyes narrowed in disgust. “It’s hard not to.”

Arthur slowly approached Saba. Only a few feet now separated the two. As Arthur got closer, Saba noticed that sense of exhaustion also consumed Arthur’s face. He noticed the same purple circles beneath his eyelids that his mother had every morning.

Arthur slightly chuckled and said, “I know who you are as well, Saba Reynolds.”

Saba’s stomach tightened. He did not expect to be easily identified. “How?” he asked.

With hesitation, Arthur proceeded, “You were probably too young to remember.” In confusion, Saba remained silent.

Arthur looked through the shelter windows and pointed at the continuation memorial outside. “Right there,” he said with a firm voice, “19 years ago, there was a district riot for food. Children were being killed. So, my brother and I came to deliver supplies.”

He paused for a brief moment. It appeared difficult for him to speak. But he continued softly, “The crowds were violent. I had never seen anything quite like it. Families were running. Children were being separated from their parents.”

Saba began to listen carefully. He was confused about what exactly this had to do with him. But Arthur clarified, “You were grabbed during the outburst. But my brother pulled you away before you were hurt.”

Saba’s mind began to resurface small fragments—though nothing clear. He vaguely remembered the pouring rain. The sirens. The shouting. It seemed chaotic, but he remembered being carried through a crowd.

“Before we returned you to your parents,” Arthur continued. “You asked why we dressed differently from everyone else.” Signs of a smile began to appear on Arthur’s face. “Most children avoided us,” Arthur said. “Most adults too. But you were one with many questions.”

Saba’s face scrunched a bit. “I was just a kid,” he responded.

“Exactly,” Arthur Replied. “And clearly not one who listened to their parents.”

For a moment, Arthur’s story marinated in the air. The words sat between Saba and Arthur.

“So what?” Saba muttered defensively. “Did you come here to see the downfall of District 11?”

Calmly, Arthur looked around the shelter. He then stepped closer to Arthur—a distance that seemed uncomfortably close. But it provided them a safe space, as volunteers could no longer hear their exchange over the natural noise of the room

“No,” Arthur said softly. “I came because this place reminds me of my brother.”

To the public, Bruce Tame had not been seen for the last three years, as he was burdened with the responsibility of managing worldwide Cloud V operations.

So Saba was confused by this response and instilled with unexplained irritation. “You mean the brother managing this corruption?”

This time Arthur completely looked away. “You shouldn’t speak on things you don’t understand.”

“There it is,” Saba muttered. “The warning.”

Remaining calm, Arthur responds, “It wasn’t a warning.”

The silence grows in the food bank as the one-sided, verbal sparring match continues. “You people always talk like you’re above everyone else.”

Arthur stared at him for a long moment. “You think my family controls the system? We just make the implant. Sure, we created continuation, but it’s not that simple. It hasn’t been for a while. It’s way beyond us now.”

“You don’t,” questioned Saba.

There is an unexpected emotion that Saba begins to notice on Arthur’s face. Arthur doesn’t appear to be offended by his outburst but rather afraid. Arthur surveilled his surroundings briefly for any eavesdroppers. He then responded, “My brother failed continuation three years ago,” Arthur struggled to say.

The space inside Saba’s mind went silent. But Arthur continued, “My father decided it was best to keep this a secret from the world. He believes that it’s best for the people to believe that Tame royalty controls the system. It creates uncomfortable confidence in the system, but public confidence would collapse if people discovered Cloud V couldn’t protect its own blood.”

Saba’s face was overtaken by disbelief, and he searched Arthur’s desperately for any signs of manipulation. He believed there had to be. “You’re lying,” shouted Saba.

Everyone in the shelter heard this. They were now staring at Saba and Arthur. The tension between the two was evident. Arthur had given up the quiet approach. “I wish I was,” Arthur exclaimed. “I am well aware of what the people think of me, but that is out of my control.” Arthur began to slowly step away from Saba. It was now a message for everyone in the food shelter. “I am no different from you. I too have spent my entire life terrified of the system.”

And just for a moment, Saba began to feel for him. But he couldn’t withhold his frustrations. “You still benefit from it,” Saba said coldly.

Arthur nodded slowly. No words. No expressions. No attempt to defend himself. He simply continued about his day and walked away. But Arthur’s acceptance unsettled Saba, and his anger had grown even more.

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When Arthur exited the food bank, Saba decided to follow him. He was sure that Arthur Tame was evil and felt destined to prove it. It was an easier task than Saba anticipated. Arthur continued his daily visits to district 11. So, wherever and whenever the cavalry of large, armored Cloud V vehicles appeared, Saba was there. It became clockwork.

But over the days, Saba found only contradictions to his beliefs. He found Arthur visiting continuation memorials alone at night. He once found Arthur donating to the local relief shelters throughout his district. Today, he found Arthur sitting for hours in front of what Saba suspected to be Arthur’s brother’s grave. “R.I.P. Bruce,” it wrote on the tombstone. It was followed by no last name.

Arthur only moved once—to aid a helpless stranger who had suddenly fainted under a tree. None of this made sense to Saba. His irritation had begun to peak. Arthur seemed just as ordinary as anyone else. It left Saba confused. “Maybe the world is more complex than oppression,” he thought to himself. But without reason, Saba simply couldn’t accept this possibility.

That same night, Arthur walked along the sidewalk near the bushes. “You’re not very good at following people,” Arthur said without turning around. “I hope you have found what you were looking for.”

Arthur was aware that Saba had been following him the past few days. He slowed his pace slightly, almost inviting Saba out from hiding rather than exposing him.

Saba felt the embarrassment settle in. He stepped out of the bushes and watched as Arthur walked away. He stood in silence. He wrestled with the idea that maybe Arthur was normal. In shame, Saba returned home.

It was after midnight. As he lay in bed, he was comforted by black skies that consumed the world-state. In the calm, he reflected.

But he became slightly unsettled. He began to hear the distant bells ring softly for those who had already failed continuation. He was more scared than ever. He thought, if Bruce Tame really failed the continuation, there is no premise for making it to tomorrow.

Saba's eyes slowly closed. And soon, the morning arrived. It was 7:30 A.M. The greyish light shone through Saba's window. You could hear his parents arguing from outside the house. Outside, traffic slowly returned to life. Across the street, Arthur Tame stood motionless beside a grey, armored vehicle toward Saba's window. Waiting. Minutes passed. Then more. But no movement came from within.